

MARGARET RIVER AUSTRALIA



Venison Among the Vineyards

South of Perth, on Australia's wild western coastline, Margaret River is a region of natural abundance. Blessed with a maritime Mediterranean climate, its renowned vineyards thrive within the bush landscape, bordered by a river on one side and untamed coastline on the other. Local produce is king here, and the perfect match for the area's fine wines is venison, the meat of kings.



With its rich agricultural soils, life-giving river, dense bushland, and isolated setting on one of Australia's wildest stretches of untouched coastline, the commercial development of Margaret

River was destined to evolve much more slowly than its natural industry. Alfred and Ellen Bussell built the first homestead here in 1875, but it was another 55 years before a scant collection of three houses allowed the area to declare itself a town.

Little has changed in the last 100 years. Though it now boasts a population of 11,000, the area is still dominated by farming and viticulture. Beef cattle, sheep, and deer graze in and around one of the nation's largest wine regions, farmed to feed the appetites of the questing gourmets who flock here each year to devour their favorites among the Margaret River delights.

It's the deer farming that inspires some of the area's greatest culinary experiences. Local couple Graham and Cynthia Morrison established their farm here in 1977, when few people were aware of the combined great taste and health benefits that venison

had to offer, but from its humble beginnings the venison farm has gone on to supply its lean and sweet meat to chefs in the local area and across Australia. Local cooks now serve up tender venison dishes that lend a new richness to old favorites, such as venison spare ribs, slow-cooked in a sticky-sweet barbecue-style sauce, or elegant venison carpaccio teamed with capers and Kalamata olives. Wintry venison osso bucco with chorizo and beans is ideal sustenance after a day spent relaxing on Margaret River's world-renowned surf beaches or trawling the cellars of its many internationally acclaimed wineries.

It is this diversity that propels the region from being a one-day stopover to a multidimensional vacation destination. This is a place to indulge every facet of your personality: the wine aficionado, the adventurer, the surfer, the artist, the naturalist, and the adventurous gourmand. Because as much as the region is a haven of natural splendor, it is the focus on food and wine that makes it stand out among the nation's coastal hot spots. Margaret River provides a heady change of pace – and tastes – from everyday life.



Above The shoreline of Prevelly Park, on the Margaret River Estuary

Margaret River Wines

Wine tasting is a feature of any trip to Margaret River, and most vineyards offer tastings alongside gourmet nibbles or elegant lunches. **Vasse Felix** (www.vassefelix.com.au) is the region's oldest vineyard and its wines are some of the most acclaimed. You can enjoy a tasting in its subterranean Cellar Door tasting shop, or try them with food in the winery's elegant restaurant, which has gorgeous views over the vines. **Leeuwin Estate** (www.leeuwinestate.com.au) lays claim to one of the region's best Chardonnays – which is no mean feat, given that the region is famed for its Chardonnay grape. Tasting is a must. **Bootleg Brewery** (www.bootlegbrewery.com.au) offers a change for those nearing vineyard saturation. Its award-winning ales and lagers can be enjoyed at tables outside in its large and pretty grounds.

The Best Places to Eat Venison

Voyager Estate expensive

Just as the glorious natural surroundings of the Margaret River region amaze visitors, so too does the Voyager Estate. The combination of atmospheric grandeur, striking rose gardens, and gastronomic excellence – all wrapped up in a pretty Cape Dutch architectural package – is almost too good to be true. And the food is as magnificent as the surroundings. Chef Nigel Harvey does his utmost with the astoundingly good fresh, local produce that comes under his fingertips, including, of course, Margaret River venison, farmed a mere cork pop away. Harvey's deft touch makes the meat shine, in dishes such as his delicately sweet venison carpaccio, matched innovatively with the fresh spiciness of radish and watercress and the bite of Manchego cheese. It is a dish complemented by the blackberry, dark-chocolate, and oaky aromatics of the estate's well-regarded Cabernet Sauvignon-Merlot blend. Dishes change with the season, so prepare to be surprised.

Lot 1, Stevens Road, Margaret River; open 10 AM–4:30 PM daily; www.voyagerestate.com.au

Also in Margaret River

Go to the source at **Margaret River Venison** (www.mrvenson.com; *inexpensive*) where you can pick up venison steaks, sausages, or marinated kebabs to cook on the barbecue. For something a little more formal there is **Must** (www.must.com.au; *expensive*), a stellar wine bar and restaurant where venison takes on a more sophisticated tone.

Also in Australia

In the small South Australian town of Mount Compass, Judith Phillips is renowned for the venison meat pies she makes and sells at **Mount Compass Venison** (+61 8 8556 8216; *inexpensive*). In Victoria, relish autumnal venison *pithivier* crammed with mushrooms and chestnuts at **Gigi's of Beechworth** (www.gigisofbeechworth.com; *expensive*) in this historic gold-mining town.

Around the World

The reindeer is native to Finland, and there are few better places to experience superbly cooked venison. The top spot in Helsinki is the two-Michelin-starred **Chez Dominique** (www.chezdominique.fi; *expensive*), where venison and oyster tartare is a must. Also in the capital but lower on the price ladder is **Lappi** (www.lappires.com; *moderate*), where traditional sautéed venison comes with mashed potatoes and lingonberries, served in a chic update of the traditional Scandinavian log cabin.